# Los Angeles Times

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## Campaign season of surprises is coming to a peak

Eventful twists create a chance Democrats could win House and maybe the Senate too.

By Justine McDaniel

WASHINGTON — An acutely contentious and historically expensive midterm campaign barrels to a finish Monday, on the eve of elections that will set the nation's course for the remaining half of President Trump's second term.

Republicans are bracing for a backlash from voters as Democrats prepare for gains — but the magnitude of any "blue wave," and whether it could sweep not only the U.S. House but also the Senate into Democratic control, will be the key question as Americans finish casting ballots Tuesday.

Early voting had already seen strong turnout, including among influence blocs such as Latino and Black voters. Candidates spent the weekend crisscrossing their states and pulling in surrogates to make a final push for voters still on the fence.

Capping a turbulent first half of Trump's second term, the campaign has been defined by affordability and economic issues that have created headwinds for Republicans and spurred a possible turn toward Democrats by voters. And as Trump has pushed the limits of executive power, the midterms could act as a consequential check on his presidential reach.

In recent polls, voters have consistently put Democrats several points ahead on the generic ballot and

[See **Surprises,** A6]

**Endorsement stuns Democrats**

Democrat Haley Stevens backs Republican Mike Rogers in the Michigan Senate race. **NATION, A3**



Carlin Stiehl For The Times



David Butow For The Times

**DEMOCRAT** Xavier Becerra, top, meets supporters in Irvine while Republican Steve Hilton wears a mask of his rival on Halloween in Highland Park.

## Governor hopefuls barnstorm in final push

Becerra, Hilton trade barbs as they crisscross the state to drum up support in the last stretch

By Seema Mehta and Nicole Nixon

Donning a creepy mask of Democratic rival Xavier Becerra, Republican gubernatorial candidate Steve Hilton dashed around a children's Halloween event dishing out candy and warnings about potential liberal tax policies.

"Vote for Becerra, and your parents will have to pay every mile they drive. Isn't that great?" Hilton sarcastically said at a trunk or treat gathering Saturday in Highland Park. "These children are very pricey because if their parents vote for Becerra, they will be taxed every mile they drive. Yay! Yay! Mileage tax! Mileage tax! Mileage tax! Mileage tax!"

Becerra was not spooked when he heard of Hilton's get-up and put-down.

"I suspect, if he takes off that mask, you'll see Donald Trump right underneath," Becerra, a former congressman, state attorney general and member of President Biden's Cabinet, said at a campaign event in Sacramento on Saturday. "That's who he really is. Either that or he's a clown."

With Tuesday's election barreling toward them, Becerra and Hilton traded barbs and did their best to gin up support as they crisscrossed California in what has been a relatively sedate

[See **Governor,** A7]

## Bass, Raman took different paths to meet the moment

Incumbent and L.A. native is in a tight battle with immigrant rival in mayor's race.

By Noah Goldberg

When Karen Bass was first elected to the California state Assembly in 2004, Nithya Raman was halfway across the world, fresh out of college and working in the slums of Delhi, India.

Raman had visited Los Angeles for the first time only a year before. Bass, meanwhile, had already called L.A. home for more than half a century as she built a career as a physician's assistant, then as an activist, and finally as a politician.

The two women who have charted vastly different life paths are now locked in a contentious battle for mayor of Los Angeles. When the votes are finally tallied after election day Tuesday, the job will go to one of them: Bass, a daughter of South L.A. and the civil rights movement who committed her life to public service, or Raman, who moved to Los Angeles 13 years ago with her husband, hoping, like so many before them, to discover whatever their future might be.

Raman's relative newness to the city has become a talking point on the campaign trail for the Bass campaign and the mayor's surrogates, who have painted the challenger as ignorant of the city's sometimes painful past, including hammering Raman over a seemingly positive remark she made about former Police Chief Daryl F. Gates, who led the force during the 1991 videotaped police beating of Rodney King.

"It's one thing to be new. That's the secondary issue," Bass said in an interview with The Times. "But if you want to lead the city, you would think that you would know some of the most important moments in L.A. history."

Raman's response: Los Angeles was built by people like herself who came here seeking a better life and new opportunities.

"This city welcomed me with open arms. So when the mayor keeps saying I'm not really an Angeleno, she's attacking more than me. She's rejecting the very DNA of Los Angeles: a city where people from everywhere can find a place to belong and to build a dream," Raman said in a statement.

Karen Ruth Bass was born in South L.A. in 1953, though her family moved to the Fairfax District when she was young.

She grew up a news junkie, watching and listening to the news with her father during the civil rights movement, seeing how difficult integration was in the South.

As she watched the Rev. Martin Luther King Jr. fight racial discrimination in the South, Bass witnessed whites abandoning the Fairfax District as Black families moved in.

"The white neighbors moved so fast I never met them," she said. "I don't know if there's a word faster than flight."

At 14, Bass signed up her mother to be the precinct

[See **Mayor,** A6]

**Candidates sprint to the finish line**

Bass and Raman take veiled shots at each other as they crisscross L.A. to campaign. **CALIFORNIA, B3**

## Fewer child-care options, soaring costs

Parents face pricier alternatives as UCLA and Samuel Goldwyn facilities plan to close.

By Emily Woodruff

Jillian Griffith had just gotten her 21-month-old to sleep and was sitting down for a story with her 4-year-old when she glanced at her phone and saw an urgent email from preschool. An enormous problem had just landed in her lap.

On Nov. 20, the 35-year-old Samuel Goldwyn Foundation Children's Center would close, the email said. Its operators blamed Hollywood's downturn and the flight of 4-year-olds to California's free transitional kindergarten programs.

Griffith's household budget had already felt the sting of the industry's troubles as her husband, a TV writer, weathered the strike. Now they would also have to find a new preschool in a shrinking and exorbitantly priced market.

"It felt like a whiplash of news," said Griffith, a museum professional, who estimated most of her salary goes to child care. At "Sam G," as parents call it, that's $3,233 per month for children under 2.

The closure exposes how working parents in Los Angeles face increasingly fragile lifelines to stable child care essential to family life. Parents — many of whom do not qualify for state subsidies — are financially hammered, paying thousands of dollars a month for care as the centers they desperately need struggle to stay afloat and the institutions that support them pull back.

"Your whole life becomes consumed with ... how do we find child care?" Griffith said.

The Goldwyn closure comes as another major Los Angeles institution retreats from providing care. UCLA

[See **Child care,** A8]

*Voices* **PATT MORRISON** COLUMNIST

## California has a rich history of reining in the uber-wealthy

The billionaire tax proposal is just the latest example of regular folks pushing back on the 1%

The New Testament has a lot to say about the poor, but it is short and not very sweet on how tricky it is for the rich to get into heaven.

California, however, has proved to be a heaven on Earth for big-league moneymakers — billionaires, in modern-day dollars — for almost as far back as there were fortunes to be made.

In its 176 years of statehood, California has become vastly rich, leading the ranks not just among states but among nations. Its current billionaires may number as many as 200. Forbes magazine puts 85 Californians on its list of the 400 richest Americans.

Over those decades, tycoons have leveraged their fortunes to shape the state with their railroads, mines, newspapers, oil businesses and ranching and agriculture.

Yet in industrialized society, as in physics, every action can generate that equal and

[See **Morrison,** A10]

**Suit dismissed in Alaska Senate race**

Justice Department sought to block certification if GOP incumbent Sen. Dan Sullivan loses. **NATION, A3**

**A marvel from stage to screen**

The late veteran actor Patrick Stewart never lost his sense of wonder. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

**Rams win battle of Los Angeles**

Blake Corum and Kyren Williams score in a 24-9 victory over the winless Chargers. **SPORTS, D1**

**Weather**

Lots of sunshine. L.A. Basin: 76/57. **B6**

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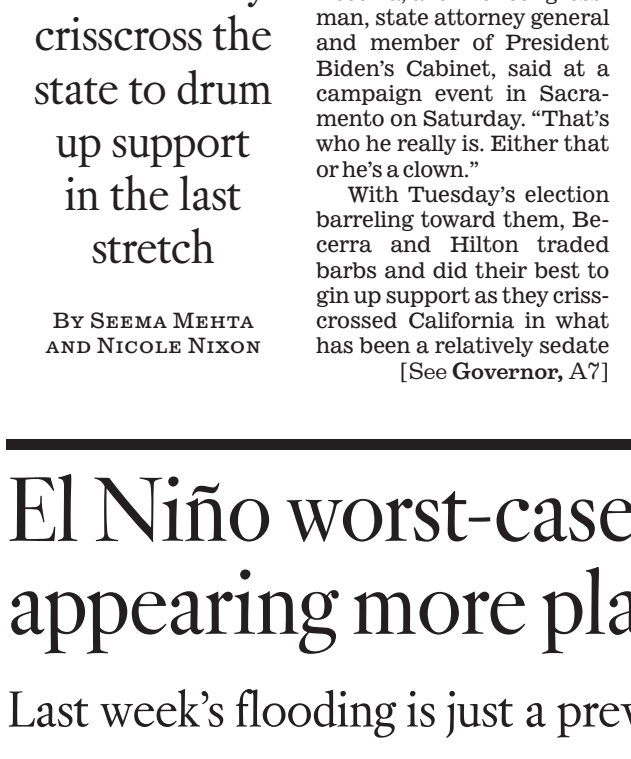
## El Niño worst-case scenario appearing more plausible

Last week's flooding is just a preview, experts say

By Rong-Gong Lin II and Sean Greene

**Swollen seas**

Sea levels on the California coast were more than 1 foot higher than would be expected due to a hotter ocean — influenced by El Niño-fueled Kelvin waves coming up from the equator.




Copernicus Marine Service, NOAA Tides & Currents, William Sweet / NOAA National Ocean Service

Sean Greene Los Angeles Times

The significant coastal flooding that hit Southern California in recent days points to what a worst-case scenario would look like in an El Niño-fueled winter with sea levels expected to rise even higher.

Last week's flooding was so bad because of two events that are expected to worsen over the next few months: a record-hot ocean raising sea levels combined with higher-than-normal tides. A third factor would be powerful storms that bring big waves.

How these three factors play out — and whether they occur simultaneously — will determine how punishing this winter will be for the coast.

The tides themselves were moderately high last week, but they, in combination with record ocean temperatures, were enough to push up sea levels significantly.

The average sea level was 1.4 feet higher than expected in San Diego, 1.3 feet higher in Los Angeles and 1.1 feet higher in San Francisco for the week ending Friday, according to an analysis of data provided by William Sweet, an oceanographer with the National Oceanic

[See **El Niño,** A14]